Faced with the threat of increasing urbanization and industrialization, the Sierra Club sought to protect the natural environment for people's enjoyment.

A greater awareness of humans' relationship with the environment led to the emergence of a more politically active environmental movement in the second half of the 20th century. This took off in the 1960s, when the Cold War was at its height and the Cuban Missile Crisis of 1962 brought the US and the Soviet Union to the brink of nuclear war, galvanizing calls for nuclear disarmament among many campaigners.

In this atmosphere, the idea of conserving particular natural sites, as in the national parks system in the US and the UK, gave way to a much broader concept of environmentalism. Several organizations emerged with a strong activist agenda involving mass protests and direct action.

"Only through care for the environment can the livelihoods of those most dependent on it be sustained."

Petra Kelly

Organized protest

One of the first of the activist organizations was Friends of the Earth. It was founded in the US in 1969 by a group that included conservationist David Brower, a former leader of the Sierra Club, with the aim of preventing the building of nuclear power plants. Politically active from the outset, Friends of the Earth continues to lobby governments across the world and campaigns on a broad range of environmental issues, emphasizing the importance of sustainable economic development. In 1971, a small group of activists in North America formed the Don't Make a Wave Committee to protest against nuclear bomb testing by the US on the island of Amchitka, Alaska. The organization favored direct action rather than political lobbying and chartered a boat to sail to the island in protest. The publicity generated